

C18 B SUPPORT FOR VICTIMS OF DOMESTIC VIOLENCE | O (MAX : 2 PT)

Intent : Increase availability and access to support services, resources and care for victims of domestic violence.

Summary : This WELL feature requires projects to implement a policy that supports victims of domestic violence and to educate employees on the domestic violence resources that are made available by the project.

Issue : Domestic violence is the most common form of gender-based violence across the world.¹ Women are disproportionately affected, with violence most commonly perpetrated by men against women.² The World Health Organization estimates that around 30% of women who have been in a relationship experience some form of physical and/or sexual violence perpetrated by an intimate partner.³ The impact of this violence is severe: globally, it is estimated that up to 38% of murders of women are committed by a male intimate partner.⁴ Beyond fatal outcomes, domestic violence can lead to a range of adverse health consequences, including higher risk of injuries, sexually transmitted infections (including HIV), depression, anxiety and substance misuse.¹ Moreover, the social and economic consequences of domestic violence are significant, including loss of wages and inability to work, as well as increased risk of homelessness.^{1,3,4} The deep impacts of domestic violence are not just felt at home, but also carried into the workplace: research shows that at work, victims are more likely to have reduced performance and productivity and increased absenteeism and turnover.^{5,6}

Solutions : Workplaces can play a role in responding to domestic violence through policies designed to protect and support victims.⁵⁻⁸ It is also important for workplaces to develop supportive and non-judgemental environments in which employees feel comfortable and safe disclosing any violent situation they may be facing.⁷ Employers can help protect victims through various measures, such as confidential protocols for reporting, reviewing and responding to an incident, ability to change workplace location and start and finish times, increased security for workplace access, call screening procedures and specific emergency response procedures.^{5,7,8} Countries such as New Zealand, the Philippines and parts of Canada have introduced legislation that promotes best practices among employers to support victims of domestic violence, including paid time off for victims and financial resources to support relocation.⁹⁻¹¹ By providing policies and resources to support victims and educate employees, employers may play a role in helping to reduce the physical and mental impacts of domestic violence.^{7,12}

PART 1 SUPPORT VICTIMS OF DOMESTIC VIOLENCE (MAX : 2 PT)

For All Spaces:

1: Domestic violence policy

The project or organization makes available to all eligible employees a domestic violence policy that meets the following requirements:

- a. Provides employees who are victims of domestic violence at least ten days of leave, paid at the employee's full salary or wages, during any 12-month period. Leave must meet the following requirements:^{5,7,8,12}
 1. Distinct from paid time off, sick leave and family leave.
 2. If requiring incident disclosure for employees to qualify, takes steps to protect employee privacy.
 3. Does not require a prerequisite minimum qualifying period of employment before an employee is eligible to take leave.
- b. Outlines a clear protocol for incident reporting and response that includes the following:
 1. Process for employees to confidentially report incidents of domestic violence, including one or more designated contacts that employees can approach confidentially for support when reporting incidents.⁸
 2. Process of incident response that includes consultation with the victim, prioritizes victim privacy and safety and ensures incident disclosure will not adversely impact victim employment status.
- c. Offers employees who report domestic violence incidents at least two of the following:
 1. Flexible working arrangements (e.g., adjusted work hours or location).^{5,7,8,12}
 2. Heightened security measures (e.g., call screenings, controlled workplace access, duress alarms, changes to contact information, worksite security escorts).^{2,5,8}
 3. Referrals to local support organizations, community groups and crisis lines, including those available through Employee Assistance Programs (EAPs).^{8,12}
 4. Temporary accommodations or financial support to cover the costs of temporary accommodations.⁵
- d. Policy and related resources provided by the organization are easily and confidentially available (e.g., via a health portal, mailed communications, employee website) to all employees and reviewed and adjusted (as needed) annually by the organization. Policy must be made available to all new employees during onboarding.^{2,5}

2: Employee education

The project or organization offers in-person or virtual trainings (e.g., workshops, seminars) that meet the following requirements:

- a. Are required of all managers and made available to all employees.^{2,8}
- b. Covers the following topics:^{7,12}
 1. The relevant domestic violence policy and resources.
 2. Signs and symptoms that a person may be a victim of domestic violence.
 3. How to appropriately respond if a colleague or direct report discloses that they or another employee is experiencing domestic violence.

Note :

This feature is a beta strategy and has an additional documentation requirement (beta feature feedback form). The feedback form supports IWBI in developing new features that are effective and applicable to projects around the

world.

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